

From Village Fields to Defense Frontlines: How DCX's Raghavendra Rao Is Building India's Aerospace Future

The son of farmers from Karnataka's Hosakote village has transformed his electronics manufacturing company into a defense powerhouse, championing India's quest for technological self-reliance

In the gleaming boardrooms of Bengaluru's tech corridor, Dr. H.S. Raghavendra Rao cuts an unlikely figure for a defense industry titan. Born in 1969 to an agricultural family in rural Karnataka's Hosakote village, the 55-year-old founder and Chairman of DCX Systems has spent the last decade quietly building one of India's most promising aerospace and defense companies—one that's now positioned to become a cornerstone of the nation's military-industrial ambitions.

"Our vision has always been crystal clear," Rao reflects, his voice carrying the conviction of someone who has witnessed India's transformation firsthand. "We're not just manufacturing components; we're establishing DCX as a product company through technology transfer, moving India from dependency to self-reliance in critical defense technologies."

That vision is rapidly materializing. Since founding DCX in 2011 alongside co-founder Neal Jeremy Castleman, Rao has orchestrated a remarkable growth trajectory that saw revenues surge from \$46 million to \$146 million between 2019 and 2022. The company's November 2022 IPO, which raised ₹500 crore and was oversubscribed 76 times, marked not just a financial milestone but a validation of Rao's strategic pivot from traditional electronics manufacturing to high-end defense systems.

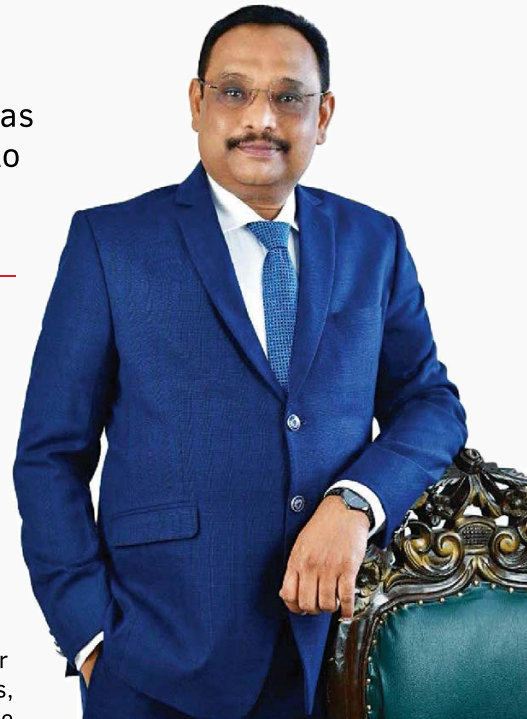
The transformation accelerated dramatically in April 2025 with the launch of ELTX, a groundbreaking joint venture with Israel Aerospace Industries' ELTA division. This partnership represents far more than a business deal—it's the embodiment

of Rao's ambitious plan to position DCX as India's premier radar and electronic warfare systems manufacturer. Complementing this defense focus, DCX has also established NIART Systems, another strategic joint venture with ELTA, dedicated to developing cutting-edge Long Range Obstacle Detection Systems for improving safety and efficiency in India's expanding railway network.

"The ELTX joint venture is our spearhead initiative," Rao explains, outlining his strategy to localize production of airborne maritime radars and fire-control systems. "We're moving from being contractors to becoming innovators, with technology transfer at the core of our Make-in-India commitment."

Under Rao's stewardship, DCX has secured India's coveted Category-A Defence Industrial License—the most sensitive classification that enables manufacturing of radar, electronic warfare, and avionics systems. This regulatory moat, combined with over \$600 million in executed offset projects, has established DCX as a trusted partner for global defense primes including Lockheed Martin, ELTA, and Rafael.

The numbers tell the story of accelerating momentum: DCX's order book stands at ₹2,697 crore as of June 2025, with Q1 FY26 revenue jumping 61% year-over-year to ₹222.16 crore. Recent contract wins underscore the company's expanding footprint, including a ₹483 crore ELTA order, a significant ₹1,250 crore order from L&T, and ₹840 crore in Lockheed Martin contracts—demonstrating DCX's growing appeal beyond



Dr. H.S. Raghavendra Rao
Founder, Chairman & Managing
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traditional offset arrangements.

But for Rao, the metrics matter less than the mission. "Every system we build, every technology we master, contributes to India's Aatmanirbhar Bharat vision," he says. "We're not just building a company; we're building capabilities that will secure India's defense future for generations."

With his honorary doctorate in Business Management and a trophy case full of international awards, Rao has earned recognition as both entrepreneur and patriot. Yet he remains focused on execution, driving DCX's evolution from cable assemblies to cutting-edge radar systems—a transformation that mirrors India's own journey from dependence to defense manufacturing leadership.

Dr. Raghavendra Rao continues to serve as Chairman and Managing Director of DCX Systems, leading the company's strategic expansion into next-generation defense technologies.